

REASON AND BEAUTY IN KANT

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In the Critique of Judgment, in which Kant elaborates on his thoughts regarding issues surrounding the beautiful, his first definition of this concept is presented to us as the object of satisfaction (*wolgefallen*), which is independent of any interest. The goal, therefore, would be to understand how our mind investigates such objects and the questions surrounding them; thus, in his own words, Kant explains that: “taste is the faculty for judging an object or a kind of representation through a satisfaction or dissatisfaction without any interest. The object of such a satisfaction is called beautiful.” (Kant, 1974, p. 309). It so happens that, in such disinterest, satisfaction seeks for itself a universal foundation within the subject; for, in this case, it operates freely in the one who judges, and for that very reason it must find, even without a concept, its universality; that is, “through the judgment of taste (regarding the beautiful), satisfaction with an object is attributed to everyone, without, however, being based on a concept (for in that case it would be the good); and that this claim to universality belongs so essentially to a judgment by which we declare something to be beautiful” (Kant, 1974, 311). Now, if even without a concept, Kant tells us that the beautiful universally pleases, then there must be a rule in the judgment that determines this. Such foundations lie in the free exercise of taste in judging the object of beauty. And this (freedom), in turn, could only be determined by Reason.

Although the judgment of taste is not based on objective concepts, Kant demonstrates in paragraph 17 that there is a search for a standard of universal validity and that this inevitably leads us to the concept of the “Ideal,” which requires the direct intervention of the higher faculties. The author explains that “Idea properly signifies a concept of reason, and ideal signifies the representation of a singular as being adequate to the idea.” In this sense, what he calls the “archetype of taste” (Kant, 1974, p. 325) ceases to be a mere sensory response and becomes a construct of the mind, revealing that the appreciation of beauty is possible only for a being capable of projecting Ideas of Reason onto sensible forms. This rational foundation of the ideal of beauty sets the stage for understanding paragraph 42, in which Kant explores the intellectual interest in the beautiful. In moving from the “ideal” (the form appropriate to reason) to “interest,” the author confirms that human beings are truly moved by the beauty of nature only when their reason identifies in it a “trace” or “sign” of harmony with the moral law.

Nevertheless, the other three instances in which Kant defines the beautiful for us as “that which, without a concept, universally pleases; or [...] the form of an object’s finality, insofar as it is perceived in the object without the representation of an end; and [...] the beautiful is that which, without a concept, is known as the object of a necessary satisfaction.” (KU), lead us to understand that this path toward defining the beautiful always involves the moment when taste seeks its reference in that capacity which, unlike understanding, makes its comprehension possible; therefore, in the intellectual interest in the beautiful, Kant presupposes that, although the aesthetic judgment is in itself disinterested, the human soul can attach to it an immediate and habitual interest in the beautiful forms of nature, which reveals itself as a distinctive sign of a “good soul.” On the other hand, we also understand that even in cases where interest in the beauty of art, which may be mediated by vanity or mere empirical perception, has no mode of thought linked to what is morally good, the person who contemplates a wildflower, a bird, or an insect in solitude, admiring and loving them, demonstrates a disposition favorable to moral sentiment. This intellectual interest is established through “moral affinity,” for reason demands that moral ideas find in the sensible world a trace or sign of the reality of their laws, so that, when we reflect on the beauty of nature, we interpret its beautiful, free forms as a “coded language” through which nature speaks to us figuratively. Accordingly, Kant states that:

To take an immediate interest in the beauty of nature (not merely to have taste in order to judge it) is always a mark of a good soul, and that if this interest is habitual, it at least indicates a disposition of the mind that is favorable to the moral feeling, if it is gladly combined with the viewing of nature. (Kant)

This interest, however, proves to be intellectual only to the extent that it contemplates the beautiful forms of nature; for the one who takes an immediate interest in nature’s attractions rather than in its forms is merely affected empirically, but it is only the intellectual interest of the one who contemplates nature for its beautiful forms and admires them that reveals the moral in the soul, for taste alone does not instill this disposition in us, and without it, nature affects us only through its functionality, and in this, as we see, there is no beauty. Accordingly, Kant states that the prerogative “of the beauty of nature over the beauty of art [...], accords with the refined and sound way of thinking of all men who cultivate their moral sensibility” (Kant, 2016, p. 154).

In this observation of beauty in nature, therefore, there are two faculties at work that contribute to thought: the first concerns aesthetic judgment, which judges forms in a purely reflective

manner, while the second concerns the faculty of intellectual judgment, which is oriented toward the laws of practical reason. Kant precisely establishes this distinction by stating that:

We possess a purely aesthetic faculty of judgment that allows us, without concepts, to judge forms and to find, in the mere judgment of these forms, a satisfaction that we simultaneously establish as a rule for everyone, without this judgment being grounded in or giving rise to any interest. On the other hand, we possess an intellectual faculty of judgment that enables us to determine a priori, for mere forms of practical maxims [...], a satisfaction that we establish as a law for all, without our judgment being grounded in any interest, yet capable of producing it. The pleasure or displeasure in the first judgment we call the pleasure of taste; in the second, that of moral sentiment. (Kant, 2016, p. 198)

It so happens that, although these two faculties operate according to distinct principles, one disinterested and free from concepts, and the other bound to laws, reason also demands that its ideas find some correspondence in the sensible world in the same way as taste does. It is from this perspective that thought, upon encountering the spontaneous beauty of nature, establishes a bridge to morality when it transforms simple formal presentation into satisfaction through an intellectual interest in “moral affinity”; that is to say, the mind will only take an interest, in this case, in the beauty of nature, if it necessarily possesses an interest in what is morally good. And although it may sound exaggerated, Kant tells us, “this interest in nature arises only through a predisposition toward moral interest” (Kant, 170–171).

In other words, Kant argues that the interest aroused by the beauty of nature does not stem from an external moralization or from a concept imposed upon it; on the contrary, it results from the harmony between the internal functions of our own thought, since the natural object reveals itself to be “intrinsically suited” for this association by satisfying the subjective conditions of aesthetic reflection. Thus, what immediately affects us in nature is not a moral idea in itself, but the discovery that spontaneous forms are revealed in it, forms that perfectly signal the judgment of satisfaction linked to the subject’s internal and cognitive structure, allowing thought to project, in an entirely reflective manner, the beautiful, which also presupposes its own moral disposition; that is, what immediately matters in the beauty of nature is “the property in itself, the fact that it qualifies for such an association that, therefore, suits it internally” (Kant, 2016, p. 157)

Unsurprisingly, Schiller, an avowed Kantian, in his correspondence with Körner, when he states that he intends to objectify the concept of beauty, tells us that this object, although it qualifies as a phenomenon, does not pertain to the phenomena investigated by theoretical philosophy, in which nature is subject to the laws of the understanding; yet he calls certain phenomena of nature “beauty,” phenomena from which nothing is required but freedom. And since this judgment is possible only through practical reason, for only reason understands freedom, then, according to him, it is through this faculty that we develop the path to beauty. But if an object that exists in the sensible world is determined solely by itself and presents itself to the senses in such a way that no influence of matter or of an end is discernible, then it is judged as an “analogon” of the pure determination of the will; however, Schiller tells us that everything that exists in the sensible world is subject to external ends and rules, lacking autonomy. Therefore, for him, if we impose a direct moral purpose on an object, its form loses its beauty; thus, the beautiful is connected to practical reason only in terms of form, and not in terms of moral content, and just as “the self-determination of the rational is pure self-determination, morality; the self-determination of the sensible is natural determination, beauty” (Schiller, 2002, p. 72)

With this explanation, we arrive at the central point of Schiller’s thought regarding Kant. In his text on *Naive and Sentimental Poetry*, Schiller tells us that there are moments when man dedicates a certain kind of interest and love toward nature, such as in plants, animals, and landscapes, and that this, therefore, is an interest that is not of a purely aesthetic order, but a moral one, for what attracts us to its object is not its external form, but the idea it embodies: spontaneous action, inner necessity, and fidelity to its own laws. Thus, he says that the entire natural being represents what “we were” and what “we ought” to become once more through reason and freedom. For this reason, nature affects us by highlighting the contrast between its purity and the imperfections of culture itself. Consequently, this interest is not common to everyone in the same way, for, being grounded in an Idea, it requires that thought be receptive to morality. But even though sentimentality toward nature has become superficial, “manifested in the form of sentimental walks and gardens,” for Schiller, the true effect of natural beauty only reaches its full depth in those who possess this internal moral predisposition. This is why objects that are virtuous in their simplicity, such as children and pure nature, are so moving, because they have the purpose of reminding us of the truth and integrity that reason seeks to regain; thus, “such sentimentality toward nature manifests itself with particular force and more

generally through the intervention of those objects which, like children and childlike peoples, [...] such is the naive” (Schiller, p. 47).

We have only the distinction that Schiller establishes as the dual attitude of the poetic spirit toward nature: for him, the poet “is either nature or will seek it,” configuring, in the first case, the naive disposition and, in the second, the sentimental one. Thus, when the subject loses the immediate sensory harmony in which reason and the senses operated undivided, nature ceases to be a naive experience and comes to be sought as an ideal of reason. Consequently, sentimental poetry does not express a mere loss of original simplicity, but the operation of the very “moral impulse” committed to restoring, on the reflective plane, the unity between man and nature. By this I mean that, for Schiller, both sentimental and naive poetry, as art, seek their principle in reason, since in both there is a connection to morality. And by moving Schiller’s thought in this analysis, my intention is to demonstrate that certain resolutions and questions of the *Critique of Judgment* reveal, in Kant’s thought, that for both art and beauty, it is in reason that we will seek the principles of freedom. But since Schiller tells us that beauty is “the analogy of a phenomenon to the form of pure will or freedom” (Schiller, 2002, p. 59), we will identify that with Kant, such a foundation would be no different.

Thus, although Kant indicates to us that beauty, just like art in general, conforms to the form of reason and its prescriptions of freedom, he nevertheless does not confer objectivity upon it, as Schiller intended. This is because Kant always believed that in such judgments we obtain no conceptual knowledge. Therefore, although it is pleasing to designate a product of nature as a work of art or to admire it as such, this is only possible through an analogy with art itself, and it is through this analogical path that (beautiful) nature approaches the aesthetic domain. And it is precisely this rigorous distinction that also underlies the Kantian requirement that true artistic creation presupposes the use of reason as the basis for action, or as the philosopher points out: “by right one ought only to describe as art production through freedom, i.e., through a capacity for choice that grounds its actions in reason” (Kant, 2016, KU, § 43).

Finally, it is in paragraph 59 of the *Critique of Judgment* that Kant determines for us the operation between Reason and Beauty, to the extent that he demonstrates that the bridge between the aesthetic domain and the moral field does not occur through a direct submission of the beautiful to the concepts of ethics, but through a strict relation by analogy. Kant tells us how, for this function, common understanding itself comes into question and resorts to a symbolic transition by attributing moral qualities to objects of nature or art, which we call

"majestic" trees, "cheerful" fields, or "modest" colors. These expressions reveal that such phenomena awaken sensations structurally analogous to the moods generated by moral judgments. Thus, taste acts as a privileged mediator, enabling the transition from sensible attractiveness to moral interest without violent ruptures, and by symbolizing free objects, the aesthetic experience comes to "educate" the subject to find a disinterested satisfaction in the senses, confirming to us that every approximation of beauty with morality constitutes, in the final analysis, an analogy that resonates in the harmony of our faculties. Therefore, in a definitive character, when we speak of Reason and Beauty, we never determine one by the other, whether based on their grounds or even on their concepts, but, as we have seen, we merely constitute a certain proximity between the one and the other.